

STALK HER

WITHERED LOVE BLOSSOMS

In a field adorned with blossoming flowers, there existed a boy who never chose to pluck them. Amidst the vibrant blooms, He overlooked those teeming with life, instead favoring the ones marked by thorns and in the midst of withering away. From afar, I couldn't help but wonder about the reasoning behind his unconventional preference.

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CHAPTER 01

WHERE I FOUND THE BOY

Amid the crowded passway, where students are either rushing back to their dorms, going to a coke fest or a party, or rushing to lecture, I noticed a tall, dark figure. It was his aura that separated him from the rest. While everyone avoided him, creating a circle of emptiness, I felt drawn, almost as if he were pulling me. However, this figure quickly vanished. His presence lingered in my thoughts, igniting a curiosity that refused to fade. Was he merely a figment of my imagination or something more profound—a soul calling out for recognition in a world that often overlooks the extraordinary in the ordinary? The memory of that brief encounter remained etched in my heart as I lived as an ordinary university student.

Our paths unexpectedly crossed on an ordinary Monday after concluding my lectures. He hurried past me, his steps urgent, as if chasing after something elusive. An unexplainable curiosity, or perhaps something more profound, impelled me to trail this mysterious figure to a parking lot situated twenty minutes away from where my car awaited. Adjusting my course, I became determined to unravel the enigma surrounding him. I needed to know and figure out who he was. Walking behind, trying to act normal, I pulled out my phone, checked the weather, and glanced at my watch. I had to stay concealed. We had been walking for some time now. As we approached the multilevel parking garage, I saw a silhouette of a girl.

The boy, a silent specter in the shadows, meticulously maintained his distance from the girl. Questions raced through my mind like a relentless storm: Why? Why was he stalking her every move? What sinister plan lurked behind his secretive pursuit? Our footsteps, amplified by the concrete structure, resonated with an ominous rhythm as they ventured deeper into the maze of cars. One following another, followed by

another, each step throbbing with intensity. What impending climax awaited, and how could I justify my presence if they uncovered me? Panic surged as I navigated through the parked cars. A sudden halt. He ceased just before she reached her destination, pivoted, and retraced his steps. What had I just borne witness to? The air hung heavy with the aftermath of an inexplicable event, and my heart pounded in sync with the pulse of the enigma unfolding before me.

With caution, I took one step at a time, trying my best not to make it seem obvious that I was following him back. I needed to figure out what this creature was. He was moving fast once again, in a hurry to get somewhere. One giant stride at a time, he walked faster than me. Had he noticed me? Was I too close? He slowed down and started walking into the shadows, then vanished.

During lectures, my eyes ceaselessly scanned the crowded halls, searching for a glimpse of his distinctive figure. I found myself jotting down details about him in the margins of my notebook, the edges filled with sketches and hastily written thoughts. The lecture material blurred into the background as my mind fixated on unraveling the enigma that was the boy. Even during meals, the aroma of the food failed to register as he consumed my thoughts. I absentmindedly chewed on tasteless bites, my mind far away, imagining the boy's every move and the reasons behind his peculiar actions. The world around me transformed into a hazy backdrop, overshadowed by the image of the boy who had become the focal point of my existence.

He entered my dream. We stood in a field full of flowers. I was at a distance where I could see the boy's silhouette. He was kneeling down, and it seemed he was whispering to the flower. I walked towards him, slowly – very slowly as I didn't want him running away. I wanted to see him. He didn't run; he stayed kneeling, holding onto a flower that was dying in real-time. This flower was withering away, something I had never seen before. I hovered above him, seeing tears dripping down his cheeks and

onto his palm, hitting the dying flower. The flower seemed to be healing, returning to life from his tears as if he allowed it to bloom again. I reached out, trying to tap him on his shoulders, but he was a mere hologram figure; my hands went through him. He stood up, and alongside him stood the flower, blooming again. He just stood and walked away. I asked him, "Where are you going? Who are you?" I pleaded for him to turn around and let me see him. I took a few steps forward, and he stood, turned around, and started walking towards me. His face was a blurry, censored type; I couldn't see what he was. He wore an all-black outfit, a long, flowing robe adorned with intricate patterns that seemed to absorb the surrounding light, creating an almost ethereal effect.

He said to me "protect her"

My alarm rang. Late for my lecture, I rushed out of the house, my mind still lingering on the mysterious boy. The image of the flower field and the boy's blurred face haunted me throughout the day. I couldn't shake off the feeling that something unusual was happening, that I was being drawn into a story I didn't fully understand. During that long forty-five-minute drive to the University, I drove in silence, with just thoughts in my head. I'm tired of this game of cat and mouse. As I parked my car in the parking lot, I told myself I needed to stop dwelling on this figure. I can't keep being obsessed with it; it's affecting me. I have a million things to do, but I'm sitting here thinking about something so random that I'm wasting my time.

I walk into my boring ol' lecture with no interest in anything. I sit three rows from the front, and I get a tingling feeling – a feeling that the girl sitting right in front is "her." Why does she feel familiar? I feel like I have seen her before. Black hair, fair skin. That green top she has on grips her torso perfectly, and the blue skirt that sits right above her knees shows her pretty long legs.

I like her. She's...interesting. What is she doing on her laptop? Is that Spotify? What kind of music is she listening to? Who's her favorite artist? Wait, who is she texting? Who the hell is Ethan with a red heart next to its name? Is that her boyfriend? Does she have a boyfriend? It felt as if I must find out before my world crashed and I lost my mind. "Alright, class, that's all we have for today. On Wednesday, you have a quiz due. Make sure you complete it before coming to class," says the professor.

I pack up at her pace, matching every tick to tack; we are synchronized. She puts her laptop first, closes the backpack, grabs her phone, slows down, goes to the front, waits, then exits. I do the same. I did exactly that but a little slower; I wanted to be behind her so when she opened the door, she would hold the door and be forced to see my face.

With my ever-so-masculine voice, I can pop my perfect smile, say "Thank you!" and start the conversation. She opens the door, and I follow behind. She looks at me, and I say my line – the same line I have practiced in my head for the past hour and fifteen minutes. It worked; I was walking next to her and spoke out loud, "You go this way, too?" When we opened the second set of those oversized doors that led to the stairs, I knew something was different because most people took the elevator, but she took the stairs and I knew that. Why do I know that? This is my first time seeing her, but why does it feel like I have known her forever? Why does it feel like I know every ins and outs of her and I have seen everything about her? Know her favorite color, her name, the colors of her undergarments – why do I feel I know all this about her? We walk together, I ask her where she is going, but I know. I know where she is going. She told me she was waiting for some friends and was going to the union to meet with them. As the sweet gentleman i am il offered to hang out with her and tell her I was going the same way. We sat and chatted for a couple of hours; during our conversation, she told me everything about herself: her favorite color, what her name meant, what she

wanted to do with her life, her fear, and her lover. She told me about her lover; she mentioned having a boyfriend. Connecting the dots, I assumed it was the same Ethan with a read heart she was texting in the middle of the lecture.

All of a sudden, she does not have any “friends” to meet and never was waiting for anyone. She had lied because I take her with me to the building where my lecture is being given. She comes. Did she not say her friends were coming? What happened? Did she lie to me? After guiding her to the restroom, we went, and I entered the lecture room. I can't stop thinking about her; every one that walks through those lecture doors, I am hoping it's her. I mean, I did tell her that we could go to my lecture together. She never showed up. As soon as the lecture ended, I shoved my laptop into my backpack, grabbed my water bottle, and I sprinted toward where I felt she would be. she wasn't there.

I'm on the speedway, standing like a total lost creep, just looking in circles because I feel the sensation that she will walk past me any time now. She did not come; I stood there until the cold breeze numbed my face, and my ears felt like they would fall off, but she never came. I felt like a million rocks dropping on my shoulders, a thousand bees stinging my heart, and the very own color of my eyes fading away with every breath. Afterall why would she be there, its only once that weve ever shared a conversation. She doesn't know me the way i know her.

I desperately wanted to see her again, the way she looked at me, the way she talked to me, the way she'd smile and laugh when I told my silly little jokes. She made me feel something different, a feeling of guilty pleasure; this wasn't the feeling you feel when you are in love or like someone. This is the feeling you get when you want something you aren't supposed to. I felt guilty for liking how her lips touched each other or how she'd sway her arms when talking to me. I felt guilty for wanting to spend time with her, but I loved it at the same time. I can't help but let myself fall for her.

I decided she wouldn't come and that she had gone home, or did she? What if she is not home but with "Ethan with a read heart"? My mind is left feeling like a crumpled piece of paper; each thought is a chaotic scribble tangled with another, and every attempt to unravel them leads to a collision with the thoughts of her. It's a game of mental bumper cars, each bump a painful reminder of the unattainable. I needed an escape from my thoughts. The clock on my phone reads seven in the evening, but the early February darkness makes it feel like midnight. Not a soul in sight; the campus appears deserted. Does no one here appreciate a leisurely evening walk, I wonder? A decision forms in my mind—I need to get out, to walk beneath the stars, to breathe in the cold, fresh air, and perhaps grab a meal. The biting cold nips at my skin, and the silence is broken only by the echo of my footsteps on the deserted sidewalk. I take an unfamiliar route, meandering under the skeletal branches of trees and plucking at the bushes along the way. Slowly, I feel the mental fog lifting. Soon, I found myself on the opposite side of campus, where the student apartments reside. A sense of déjà vu creeps in. My friends don't stay on this side, so when was I here last? I continue walking until an open window on the ground floor captures my attention.

CHAPTER 02

GARDENS AND SECRETS

The open window acted as a peephole, letting me get a glimpse into a scene I had never intended to witness. In the dimly lit room, jazz music in the background, lay the girl—the same girl I found myself inexplicably drawn to. She lay on the bed, the bed of another man, immersed in conversation with him. I crouched behind a towering pine tree and dense bushes, my eyes fixed on the scene unfolding before me. Despite the suspicion surrounding my actions, I couldn't bring myself to look away. All I could hear were muffled mumbles and big laughs from here and there. Her happiness, so vivid in that moment, became a sharp blade that pierced through my chest. It was the kind of happiness one experiences in the embrace of love, a smile that blooms only in the presence of someone who holds their heart. The realization, like barbed wire tightening around my neck, left me breathless. Emotions surged within me, an overwhelming blend of sorrow and longing that spilled into silent tears dripping down my cheeks.

A sharp beam of light jolts me from the shadows, and panic tightens my chest. As I step out from the concealing embrace of the tree and bushes, leaves and dirt cling to my clothes. The campus security's flashlight, illuminating my disheveled appearance, demands an explanation. In the tension between the reality of my actions and the surreal scene I've stumbled upon, I quickly come up with a story. I tell him I was searching for my lost cat, fumbling to explain the dirt on my clothes. I inquire about the security presence at this late hour to divert attention. The officer reveals a call reporting a potential stalker, probing if I could be the culprit. I assure him of my

innocence, spinning a tale about a cooking mishap that led to the cat leaving the house. Skeptical but seemingly appeased, the security leaves me standing in the darkness. The urgency to escape grips me as I realize I must escape this precarious situation. I returned to my home with guilt and confusion heavy on my shoulders. It was well past nine, and I hadn't eaten I had no appetite after what had just happened. I headed into the shower, the hot steaming water hitting my skin. I felt a sense of relief; my knees felt weak, and I sat on the floor with the water hitting my back. I sat there with nothing but my thoughts, as if chaotic scribbles were tangled with one another. I had to pull myself together and get into bed.

As sleep beckoned, I found myself back in the middle of the field of flowers where the boy stood. I approached him, demanding to know who he was and what was happening. With a nod, he instructed me to follow. Ahead of me, he gracefully traversed the narrow path in the vast field where flowers of all different colors adorned the landscape as far as I could see. Some were tall, and some were short. The sun beamed down, but it wasn't too hot, and the wind blew gently. It felt like paradise. As we took the path, we approached a stunning view of a lake overlooking a beautiful mountain. On the tallest tree stood a treehouse – a treehouse that I had seen before but only in my dreams. This felt weird. I had been at this treehouse once before with a girl I loved. I envisioned us sitting here in the cold winter, enjoying the time we spent together as we sipped hot chocolate from our red mugs. He initiated the climb, telling me to join him.

We settled in the exact spot where I had once shared precious moments with the girl of my dreams. Sensing my contemplation, the boy broke the silence, "Black hair, fair skin, that radiant smile, the twinkle in her eyes – you're in love, aren't you?" Confused by his seemingly intimate knowledge, I questioned, "What are you talking about?" He uttered her name, "Jenifer, or does she prefer Jenefer?" Stunned, I inquired

about his connection to her. "How do you know her? What is your relationship with her?" The boy's response echoed eerily, "The same as yours. It's special, but only to you. You love her, but she doesn't. You care for her, but she doesn't. You are a gardener; you plant her in your garden, tend to her, water her, nurture her, and protect her from anything harmful. You witness it, don't you? She's slowly fading, a fragile bloom with the potential to outshine every other flower but trapped in the grasp of an inept gardener. His touch lacks the tenderness she craves, and she wilts, burdened by his carelessness. You must protect her, even if her thorns dig into your skin, drawing forth your blood. Cling to her, refuse to let go; she hangs on your care. Without your unwavering embrace, she's condemned to wilt away, and the thought of her demise stirs an ache deep within your soul." I sat there, taking in every word he said, and his voice carried a heaviness, a sadness that hung in the air. Time pressed upon him as dusk edged toward dawn, a ticking clock for our conversation. He needed to share this before the morning light swallowed him up. He confessed to being nothing more than a creation of my own mind, a scapegoat for my actions. He insisted I knew everything about her because I conjured him, a ghostly figure to shadow her and shield my obsession. At that moment, the weight of his words bore down on me, and I grappled with the reality that he claimed was merely a product of my imagination.

Awoke, disoriented, yet convinced of the reality of the encounter. Filled with fear, I grappled with the realization that I could conjure a ghostly figure to shield my obsession. Terrified of what I might be capable of, I remained in my room, paralyzed by the uncertainty of reality. The room, cloaked in shadows despite the hours passing, became a breeding ground for my spiraling thoughts. The dimness intensified my internal turmoil, mirroring the confusion within. I questioned the boundaries between reality and the ethereal, my mind entangled in a web of uncertainty. Fear, like an unrelenting specter, gripped my every thought, amplifying the darkness outside and

within. It became apparent that no matter how surreal, the dream carried a resonance that couldn't be easily dismissed. The boy's words reverberated in my mind, crafting a haunting portrait of my subconscious machinations. The girl wasn't confined to the waking world; she existed as a delicate bloom within the garden of my mind, meticulously tended to with obsessive care.

Amid this realization, the harsh quack of my phone shattered the room's stillness. The sudden intrusion jolted me from my paralysis, and with trembling hands, It was her — Jennifer. I hesitated before answering the call, my heart pounding in my chest. Her sweet and familiar voice flowed through the receiver as I picked up the phone. "Hey, it's Jenifer. I noticed you didn't come to today's lecture. Is everything okay?" Her voice carried genuine concern, a warmth that contrasted sharply with the cold reality I found myself trapped. I cleared my throat, trying to compose myself. "Yeah, just wasn't feeling well. I needed a break," I replied, my words feeble in the face of the emotional storm brewing within me. There was a brief pause on the other end as if she sensed there was more to my story. "I hope you're taking care of yourself. If you ever need someone to talk to, I'm here," she offered, her kindness like a lifeline in the tempest of my thoughts. "Thanks, Jen. I appreciate that," I mumbled, my gratitude genuine but masked by the turbulence in my mind.

As she spoke, I couldn't help but fixate on the idea that her concern might go beyond mere friendship. Was it just my wounded heart playing tricks on me, or was there a subtle tenderness in her words? The boy's haunting words echoed in my mind — "You love her, but she doesn't. You care for her, but she doesn't." Was I projecting my own desires onto this conversation? The realization that I might be crafting a narrative that didn't exist clawed at my sanity. Yet, with each shared laugh and exchanged story, a sliver of hope sprouted within me. The connection we shared felt like a lifeline, even if it was just friendship. In the midst of my tangled emotions, her

voice became a beacon, a source of comfort I desperately clung to. As we said our goodbyes, a newfound resolve stirred within me. If there were even a remote chance that she cared for me beyond friendship, I would seize it. My heart, wounded and fragile, yearned for her affection. If she were the delicate bloom in the garden of my mind, I would be the gardener she deserved. Nights turned into a routine of long phone calls and long texts. At 3:33 each night, like clockwork, her text would light up my world. Time passed – 4:44, 5:55 – though 6:66 or 7:77 did not exist, we stayed up until those hours, just chatting into the late night. As the darkness embraced us, our talks ventured into deeper waters. With every passing hour, our connection grew more intimate. She shared her deepest secrets, trusting me entirely with every detail of her life. In those moments, I felt truly special, and I was even more infatuated by her. Every casual touch and every shared text fed the flames of my obsession. I scrutinized every word, every glance, searching for a hint that our connection could transcend the boundaries of mere friendship. I wished to be with her for eternity because the way I felt around her was a feeling so strong that no drug had yet to be instilled in me. This rush, this adrenaline, dopamine, these feelings rushing to my head—I felt no more than a feigning itching to be with her every second of the day. On the days I did not see her, I lay like an empty soul, imagining a world where we were together. Like a neglected garden longing for attention, she lived in my mind at all times. Thoughts of her were like scattered seeds waiting for a chance to sprout.

CHAPTER 03

ALL OF YOU

Our interactions took on a new depth. In the shared moments between lectures and coffee breaks, I started noticing the subtle gestures of care. A glance that lingered a bit longer, a touch that held a comforting warmth—signs that went beyond the surface, beyond the ordinary.

One drunken college night, she called me, breaking the usual rhythm of our conversations. "You know, I genuinely worry when you're not around. It's like something's missing, and when you don't text me, I start to miss you," she confessed. Her voice was slurred, the vulnerability in her words piercing through the haze of alcohol. Shocked to hear these words come out of her mouth, I asked if everything was good, considering she already had a boyfriend. The complexity of her emotions added a layer of confusion to our growing connection, leaving me grappling with the unspoken tension between us. The next day, unaware of what she had said over the phone, I continued to play the role of the supportive friend, pretending as if I had never heard those words. We continued talking late into the nights, and with each conversation, the fascination grew. It wasn't just about being there for her; it was about enveloping myself in every facet of her world.

I found myself becoming a student of her likes and dislikes. What she found amusing, I found captivating. The music she enjoyed became the soundtrack to my nights, the lyrics weaving into the fabric of my thoughts. I immersed myself in her favorite books, movies, and hobbies as if adopting her interests would bring me closer to understanding the intricacies of her soul. Every detail about her life became a

treasure to be cherished. I memorized her schedule, knowing when her classes were, when she had exams, and even when she took breaks. My phone was filled with reminders, not for my life, but for hers. I justified my actions as acts of love and care. But as the obsession grew, so did the shadows of doubt. Was I crossing a line? Was this still about caring, or had it transformed into something darker? As this obsession deepened, caring for her took on a new form that went beyond the boundaries of friendship. She lived in my thoughts at all times. Before going to lectures, I would always pack myself a snack, but now, I started thinking about two. She'd told me she liked grapes. Knowing she had an exam early in the morning and she'd be hungry, I packed us grapes. Why was I doing these things?

Caught in the swirling currents of emotion, I questioned the nature of my feelings and actions. Was I driven by genuine care, or had I become entangled in a web of obsession? The boundaries blurred, leaving me on the precipice of a truth I was hesitant to confront. In the delicate dance between friendship and something more, I grappled with the shadows cast by the intensity of my emotions. The warmth that once enveloped us now seemed to flicker, casting fleeting shadows on the canvas of our connection. The realization of my growing obsession with her didn't hinder my desire to be near her. In fact, it only intensified my efforts. It was as if I had become a slave to every moment she allowed me to share with her. As our interactions deepened, I found myself unveiling the depths of my emotions.

Frustrated and confused with my emotions, I found myself at a party, heavily intoxicating myself, hoping to escape thoughts of her and enjoy the night. Yet, one drink after another, I was drawn to her. The crowded room blurred around me, the laughter and music fading into the background. Unable to resist the magnetic pull, I

called her, my voice echoing with a vulnerability I had long kept hidden. "I want you," I confessed, catching her off guard. Confusion clouded her response, "What do you mean, you want me?" "I want all of you," I pressed on, the weight of my emotions evident in my words. "I want you to be mine. You know how I feel about you, so why don't you tell me how you feel?" "I—" she stuttered, a hint of sorrow coloring her voice. "I thought we talked about this before. I have a boyfriend." "That has nothing to do with me," I asserted, determination burning in my eyes. "So what if you have a boyfriend? I want to know how you genuinely feel about me. Be honest with me." She hesitated, the weight of unspoken truths hanging heavy in the air. "I like you," she finally confessed, "When you talk, you have this magical way with words; it's like you're painting something beautiful in the air. It inspires me. You make me feel special and loved. I look forward to seeing your messages on my phone every morning. I feel guilty," she replied. "Guilt?" I questioned. "I look forward more to seeing your messages and talking to you than my own boyfriend." I asked, "Then why don't you leave him and be with me instead? I can bring you the moon and the stars; I care for you like no other," I added, my voice a gentle plea. "I want to be the one who waters and nurtures you for the rest of your life. I promise you, there is no one else in this world who's better for you than me. I want to teach you things, share moments, and create a world where it's just us." Undeterred, I delved deeper into the complexities of our connection. "You said I bring more value into your life than your boyfriend ever has or will. Logically, it doesn't make sense. Why stay with someone who brings less value into your life?" Her response hung in the air, tears dripping down her face, her nose stuffed, and her voice strained as if grappling with an overwhelming tide of emotions. "Love is complicated," she replied, "It's not always about logic. It's not that I don't appreciate what you bring; it's just different with him. I love him, and the things he does for me matter because they come from him."

Her response lingered in the air, leaving me with more questions than answers. I hung up abruptly, my heart torn to shreds. In that moment, I wanted to jump off the top floor of the parking garage headfirst, hoping I wouldn't have to live another day with any memories of her. I walked back into the party, my friends confused about where I had been all this time, said they wanted to leave and get some food. As we all stumbled around the streets and found our way inside a 7/11 convenience store, we got what looked best at 3 am on a drunk Wednesday—7/11 wings with ranch. We decided to sit outside where the breeze was blowing calmly, it was quiet, and the stars were shining. We sat and devoured this meal; the taste exploded in our mouths as if it were the best thing we had ever eaten. As we came to the end of our meal, “So who is it, who is this girl that’s driving you mad?” my friend asked. “Oh! It’s no one,” I said. “It must be someone special; you’re not one to leave the party for so long,” he said. This bottle of secrecy and emotion collided and I told him everything. I told him how pathetic I felt falling for a girl who already had given her heart to another man, I told him how much I wished she’d be mine. I told him everything as we yelled at each other for over two hours. Until our friend started viciously throwing up, we stood in front of the convenience store and argued. “She doesn’t love you the same way you love her, it’s different for her. She is using you to get the affection she fails to get from her boyfriend. Of course she doesn’t see anything wrong with their relationship; it’s because you are feeding her what she is missing, so she feels as if there is nothing wrong with her. You need to step away because as long as you keep holding her, she will keep sucking you like a parasite and won’t leave you until you are nothing but flesh and bones.” Suddenly, his words sounded so similar to the boy’s words. I don’t know if I was drunk or if he took the shape of that boy. The words he told me that night stayed

with me until the sunrise when I woke up with my head pounding and my stomach hurting. I had to end it...

CHAPTER 04

GOODBYE FOR NOW...

God, this is so fucking hard. Is it my pride or my ego, but it hurts so much not being able to obtain the one very thing I worked so hard for. I did everything so meticulously by the book. I played all of my cards so well. I learned everything I had to about her, played right into her fictional fantasy by being this perfect man, but it wasn't enough. I wasn't enough. For the right guy, she would have left her shit face of a boyfriend, but unfortunate for me, my words weren't enough. Maybe I should've been six five with blue eyes and then she would have been head over heels for me. This is not how I want my story to end. By giving up... momma ain't raise no bitch.

I am furious. Who does she think she is? I was ready to give her the moon and the stars. Baby, you can have all of me, and in return, I just asked for a piece of you. I can't, I

can't lose you. I so desperately desire you that if I were to lose you, I would lose myself.

Why did it have to be this way? The anger burns through me, a searing pain that won't be quenched. Every fiber of my being screams at the unfairness of it all. I feel betrayed by the universe, by my own heart. How could she not see what we could have been? How could she choose someone who doesn't value her the way I do?

But after the anger, the sadness comes crashing in like a tidal wave. The tears I've held back for so long finally break free. I sob into my pillow, the weight of my unrequited love pressing down on my chest. I mourn the loss of a future that will never be. The fantasies I built, the dreams I dared to dream—all shattered into a million pieces.

Denial creeps in, whispering false hopes. Maybe she'll realize her mistake. Maybe she'll come back to me. But deep down, I know these are lies I tell myself to dull the pain. I have to let go. For my own sanity, I have to move on.

Acceptance is the hardest stage. It feels like surrendering, like admitting defeat. But I see now that holding onto this hope is like holding onto a blade, and it's cutting me deeper every day. I have to let her go, not because I want to, but because I need to heal. I need to find myself again, separate from the shadow of our could-have-been.

This is my goodbye. Goodbye to the nights filled with dreams of a life together, goodbye to the desperate hope that things will change. Goodbye to the girl who unknowingly held my heart in her hands. I need to reclaim it, piece by broken piece, and learn to live without her.

So, goodbye for now. Maybe one day, our paths will cross again, and we'll both be different people. But for now, I need to let go and find my own way.